

WEEK 13 · FUGITIVITY

CLASS 2

READING 1

“The Kids in the Hall” in *Progressive Dystopia* – Shange

Progressive Dystopia: Abolition, Antiblackness + Schooling in San Francisco | Shange

Week 13, Class 2

Chapter 4: The Kids in the Hall — Space and Governance in Frisco's
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Chapter Four

The Kids
in the HallSpace and
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“Ten!”

Nyla’s sweet soprano soared above the rustle of backpacks jostling and the tinny *tink-tink-tink* of basslines filtered through off-brand white earbuds slung from shirt collars. She stood in her classroom entrance, the door as wide as her smile, as kids shuffled a bit faster to finish at their lockers.

“Nine!”

Across the hall, Kate barked at no one in particular, interjecting instructions to the students already inside between numbers—“The Do Now is on the board.”

“Eight!”

“Seven!”

Their unison is disrupted by DeAndre, who lumbered around the corner bellowing, “Ten! Nine point five!,” sparking chuckles among the three dozen or so kids left in the corridor connecting Nyla’s English class, Kate’s Trigonometry room, and my now-empty theater classroom.

“Quit cutting up, DeAn’,” Nyla chided as Kate kept counting.

He interrupted her, protesting, “But they ain’t even start counting yet on the other side.”

“Four!” Kate continued, as Brown and Black bodies filed past her to find seats in the sunny classroom. “Get in my class now or you’re not getting in without a pass!”

Rolling his eyes dramatically, DeAndre slowly sorted papers in his locker and gathered a few in his fist before closing it and checking his phone. Kate and Nyla’s classroom doors shut definitively and he looked up to see me watching him from my doorway as relative silence settled upon the corridor.

“Oh well, Ms. Shange.” He strolled past me away from Kate’s room. “I’m doing good in math anyway,” he said, then quickened his pace toward the sound of laughter spilling from the hall bench just out of sight.

The countdown system had been instituted a few years prior as a compromise after a major staff backlash over a proposal to activate the automated passing period “bell” tone that came included with an overhaul to the PA system. Student lateness was a perennial staff concern at Robeson, students both arriving to school late in the morning and getting to class after the five-minute passing period between block classes, but some teachers still balked at the thought of a centralized bell system because it risked making Robeson feel more like a typical high school. Veteran Robeson teacher Sonny Hammad even made a short PowerPoint that was more a call to arms than a bureaucratic proposal. Arguing that the prison panopticon gave way to the factory-floor clocks as a way to control working-class people, Sonny drew on his Syrian heritage and personal experience as a ditch digger to make a rousing (and successful) case against a centralized bell system. As compromise given the inconsistency of the SFUSD wall clocks throughout the building, the collective countdown was chosen to appease the various staff factions.

But why was DeAndre in the hall in the first place?

If we really want to know, we need a more rigorous accounting of both time and space, one that allows us to think of them as strategies, rather than as facts external to our analysis—*They ain’t even start counting yet on the other side!* Katherine McKittrick (2011, 2013) names the seam stitching The City to slavery *plantation futures*: “a conceptualization of time-space that tracks the plantation toward the prison and the impoverished and destroyed city sectors and, consequently, brings into sharp focus the ways the plantation is an ongoing locus of antiblack violence and death that can no longer analytically sustain this violence” (2013: 2–3). Here the plantation is not demonized as a site of absolute violence trapped in the past—instead it is rendered as the place of both death and life, the geography of both cap-

tivity and fugitivity. In the chapter that follows, I map the hallways at Robeson as one such geography, and ask how Robeson's institutional practice of carceral progressivism maps onto the political economy of restructuring San Francisco. I track the afterlife of slavery in the present plantation future at Robeson as it manifests in the links between Reconstruction-era approaches and reactions to the policing of Black comport and the management of hallway behavior in the school site. Finally, I follow the flight of the settled/slave toward what we might call a Frisco fugitivity, one that manifests in motion both within and away from the carceral city and its progressive jailers.

Corridor Customs: Walking the Halls of Robeson

Class-cutting scenes like those familiar from angsty high school films like *The Breakfast Club* and *Dangerous Minds*, where students smoke weed or gamble in the halls and stairwells, were rare at Robeson. This was due to both the limited square footage of the four connected hallways and the hassle a would-be miscreant faced. Substance use was treated in good faith as a wellness crisis, and students who were even suspected of coming to school high were mandated to go through substance use counseling on campus, as well as ongoing therapy sessions during the school day. For those caught getting high on campus, a disciplinary write-up accompanied the psychological intervention. As Sonny told my advisee Keenan after he sent him to the Wellness Center again for coming to his English class reeking of marijuana, "Dude, it's just not worth the trouble—smoke on the way home, like a fuckin' adult." Also unlikely was another trope of urban miseducation: fights. At Robeson, physical altercations between students are relatively rare. Safety was one of the top reasons families chose Robeson over larger, more established schools. On average, there were usually only one or two fistfights on the school grounds each year, while transfer students from nearby Valencia High reported that lunchtime fights had become a weekly ritual.

The corridor customs at Robeson were far less dramatic. In order to get into the halls, some young people used DeAndre's approach of never going back into class after passing period, while others might conveniently forget their books or materials, or just slip out when the teacher's head was turned. A few others would purposefully get into conflict with an instructor, hedging the bet that they would be sent into the hall to wait for a

talking-to. On occasion, teachers complained that their laminated bathroom passes had never come back after excusing a student to the restroom—the long red lanyards could be seen all the way from the other end of the hall and were supposed to avert disciplinary confrontations. Because of the easy-to-lose hall lanyards, some teachers made makeshift, and often absurd, replacement passes. For a while, students had to tote around an industrial push broom labeled “On My Way Back to Ms. O’Shea” when they stepped out of Evelyn’s science class, and others schlepped analog telephone receivers or blackboard erasers. Once in the hall, Robeson youth used their stolen minutes of class time to rebraid their edges, talk a crying friend through their drama, or just stroll along crooning a favorite song in unison with a video playing on their phone—in short, for remarkably unremarkable activities.

As Black senior Jabril put it, much to his frustration, the hallways were for *chilling*:

Every time I am in Mr. Agusalim’s class, the same students are in the hallways. And I understand if you have family problems, or things are going down on the way to school but it’s like, there’s the Wellness Center to talk to—go talk to somebody. But they don’t wanna go to class, they just want to come to school and chill in the hallways. At lunch, you could go outside, but you are *still* in the hallways. What’s the point of coming to school if you just gonna chill in the hallways? And then after school it’s like “Oh, I don’t wanna go to home,” but you are still in the halls!

Jabril’s annoyance at his peers belies easy binaries between the prerogatives of students and teachers in the school space. Like his advisor, Kate, he thinks of Robeson’s primary purpose as academic education. As a college-bound student with a 3.52 cumulative GPA, Jabril was often called upon to speak at public events and recruitment fairs on behalf of the school; he was quite invested in and identified with Robeson. Though Jabril found it irritating, couldn’t “the same students’” commitment to chill in the hallways, sometimes hours after the end of the academic day, also reflect an investment in and identification with the school space?

DeAndre, a junior whose name was often the first mentioned by students and staff when discussing behavior problems at the school, spoke of Robeson idyllically in his interview: “This school started my life for me. . . . Honestly, I think coming here changed everything. This has really—I’m not saying this just to say this, or just to make someone happy, or because you doing this [research]. This is really the best school.” When DeAndre

says Robeson is the “best school,” the comparison carries weight because of his breadth of experience. Due to expulsions and academic transfers, he went to four elementary schools and three middle schools before starting his freshman year at Robeson. However his pride of place manifested differently than Jabril’s; while Jabril was scribbling away in Pre-Calc, DeAndre was strolling the corridors as if he were the mayor. Maybe, for the Black and hyphy¹ constituency gathered in this corner of the Excelsior, he was.

While student (mis)behavior like DeAndre’s has been the focus of most of the scholarly examination of school corridors, the content of expectations for comportment has been underexamined, particularly given the raced and gendered dimensions of behavioral norms. Deeply insightful works on student resistance still tend to assume the schoolhouse walls as an analytically meaningful boundary, and educational attainment as a natural teleology (see Giroux 2003). The educational research frame engages actors in the school space as categorized first by institutional roles—students, teachers, staff—and then looks to race as descriptive of how they experience or embody those roles. But what if we reverse that logic, and analytically engage Nyla, Jabril, and DeAndre primarily as Black people surviving always already antiblack statecraft, and then see their roles as derivative of how their blackness shows up (and out)?*

This shift may help us to track the moves of race and racism across and through space, without constraining us to the inherited conventional power distribution of students and teachers. If we take schools as one of the many organs of the state’s anatomy, the cellular wall that separates it from the jailhouse and the social services office, the military bunker and the hospital ward becomes more porous, leaving us with far fewer problems that can be solved by “students” and “teachers,” and yet greater utility for the insights we can gain about Black life and death under late liberalism. For those of us invested in justice, this approach may seem disheartening because we *want* to solve problems, to make programmatic recommendations and policy shifts—these kinds of concrete wins offer immediate succor for the folks most impacted by disinvestment as well as a kind of catharsis for

* To “show out” is a Black English idiom that is a rough synonym of “to stunt”; one shows out when one intentionally performs their own greatness through self-styling and comportment and revels in it despite any external judgment. While “showing out” suggests ostentation, it is not compatible with bourgeois norms of respectability and instead tarries in the gendered and classed economy of what Deborah Thomas (2006) calls racial respect.

the overworked community-engaged researcher. However, the Black folks who made life in a janky building at the top of a hill in Frisco show us that there is more to this game than winning.

The Usual Suspects: Disciplinary Rationales at Robeson

Caught mid-text, I sheepishly tucked my phone into my back pocket as I entered the silent business meeting, only to slip it out again in order to record the proceedings. The circle of twenty-one staff members sat, eyes closed, a few fidgeting, one with her head cocked to the side as if listening for a far-away whistle. The coprincipal Tina clinked together a pair of Tibetan *ting-sha* meditation bells and they rang shrilly, to her surprise. “Whoa there!” she jumped. “Well, thanks to those who arrived on time for starting us off with mindfulness. Aaron and I were just talking about what a difference it makes in our meeting time.”

With that, Josue, a proud Pinoy² Frisco native and history teacher seated to Tina’s left, caught my eye from across the circle and bugged his eyes out and pursed his lips, creating a mash-up caricature of an English schoolmarm and elitist foodie wrapped in one. Just like the young people in Sofia’s class, Robeson’s teachers took this mindfulness business only halfway serious. Rolling my eyes at him, I refocused on the photocopies being passed around. As a way to start the agenda, Aaron had brought in an excerpt from Lisa Delpit’s *Multiplication Is for White People* (2012), a trade book focused on white teachers of Black children in the context of contemporary school reform.³ Already quite familiar with Delpit’s work, I skimmed quickly, more interested in what was missing from these four pages of isolated text. Aaron had chosen a pair of two-page passages from the “Warm Demanders” chapter, which argues that white teachers should look to the tradition of high expectations and cultural engagement as a model for their own pedagogy. In a typical Robeson move of modeling classroom best practices in professional development meetings, he then asked Robeson staff to annotate the text, choose resonant passages, debrief with a partner for five or ten minutes, and then come back to the larger circle of chairs for a full-staff discussion.

Both Nyla and Zahra, Black teachers from the greater Bay Area, raised their hands to debrief in the larger group, the former sharing her concern that due to less community-building time as a school due to draconian budget cuts handed down from Governor Jerry Brown’s office, she lacked

the close relationships necessary to be a “warm demander” for students in the hall.

“It feels really generic to be like,” Nyla effected a husky, faux-concerned voice, “‘I know you could be in class and doing better,’ but I don’t know your name.” Chuckles peppered forth.

Zahra, in her customary earnestness, pulled out Delpit’s point about living in community with your students, and that those relationships need to be built outside of the classroom. This flew in the face of Robeson narratives of the classroom being the moral and logistical center of the school, the space that determines the shape and pace of institutional life. Freedom ’fro and palm-sized green lily earrings swaying in unison as she gesticulated, she added, “You know, the girls who are in the hallway, just playing their tunes and doing their dances? I knew all their names after three weeks, just making myself go out into their spaces and connect.” Here, not only does Zahra offer a lived example of Delpit’s axiom “knowing students is a prerequisite for teaching them well” (87), but she also names the hallway as *their space* without animosity or competition, filled with rhythm rather than trouble.

Whether the hallway is “theirs” or “ours” indexes a broader tension about the rightful owners of the space of the school, and even of The City. Robeson’s founders were devotees of the Deweyian tradition of progressive schooling. There is more than a nod to a democratic notion of commonly held school space: Aaron’s head is usually the one doing the nodding; his gracefully thinning salt-and-pepper hair gives gravitas to the institutional memory he holds as cofounder and principal. Running parallel to democratic idealism is a powerful narrative of Robeson as an exceptional space—a special school, with special teachers and a special mission. In many ways, this narrative is borne out in reality. Robeson was footnoted as a *literal* exception to the teacher’s union contract governing labor conditions and evaluation structures, a concession won after a year-long negotiation process between four “Small Schools by Design,” the district, and the teachers’ and administrators’ unions.⁴

Similarly, the “alternative schools and programs of choice” designation that cofounder Elizabeth had sought from the state Department of Education also exempted Robeson from the lockstep, textbook-based curriculum that masqueraded as a decent education for most Californians. In each and every interview I conducted with students, including those who had been kicked out, they remarked about how much better Robeson was than other schools they had attended. Maricela, a Salvadoreña sophomore transfer to

Robeson, remarked: “At [my old school] sometimes I felt like I’m walking around with people who hate me, and for just no reason. Here, it’s just like, I feel chill. People are very welcoming, and like the vibes are so good here.” The “chill” feeling that Maricela cites vibrates through Robeson’s halls, echoing through high-energy greetings with daps and chest bumps and effusive compliments about hair and makeup interspersed with snippets of Spanish *chisme* and Samoan *fa’aumu* “cheee-hooo!” whoops.

However, the “vibes” at the staff meeting about the hallways were anything but chill. Aaron spoke hesitantly to the group of adults, whose mood had gone from reflective to taciturn.

“Anybody have thoughts on the yelling, in particular?”

Picking up on Zahra’s hallway marker, Aaron directed us back to the part of the excerpt where Delpit references “meanness” as a pedagogical tool. In it, she recounts an anecdote of a “tough” Black teacher whose students valued her anger as an asset to their learning. She cautions, “I am not suggesting that everyone should proceed to be mean to or yell at Black children” because that generally works better for Black teachers for whom “your own cultural background is so similar that you also associate a raised voice with caring” (Delpit 2012: 81). Aaron cleared his throat and peered one at a time around the circle at the staff members who had yet to speak up that meeting. Explicitly inviting input from those who were being quiet was by no means out of the ordinary, and indeed was in keeping with one of the original Robeson staff core values of “attending to patterns of participation.”⁵ However, Aaron’s dramatic “ahem” combined with Delpit’s commentary that yelling is probably not for you if you ain’t Black, shifted the energy in the room. The loud silence that followed was punctuated by butts shifting in seats, a side-long glance between Kate and her fellow white STEM teacher Arnie, and the flipping and refliping of the double-sided single-sheet excerpt. With Nyla and Zahra already accounted for, half of the Black staff had already spoken, making it seem more likely that Aaron brought in the Delpit text to orchestrate a moment of accountability for some of Robeson’s yellers.

Like a cable car, the conversation creaked to a roll again. The special education teacher, Ellen, lilted in her Hungarian accent, “Somebody yells, but it depends on *how* they yell,” and Nyla piped up again to push back on the effectiveness of yelling at all. Confirming my hunch that today’s professional development session was designed to get a few specific teachers to stop flexing on Black kids, Tina passed out the handout below. Titled “Escalation and De-escalation,” it included a table summarizing the previous week’s conversation about how to respond to students acting out, followed by a couple of prompts.

De-escalate	Escalate
calm voice	raised voice
“take a pause”	aggressive tone
calming hand motions	took it personally (“my class,” “you promised me”)
questions	commands (“listen”)
reference the future and positive alternatives	ranking students/pitting against each other
time for reflection	following and escorting
peer support	making it annoying to be out of class
zone defense rather than “man on man”	arguing
joking indirect approach (be more crazy than the student)	focus on “winning”
use humor and prior knowledge of student	
stay positive	
focus on resolution	

Escalation handout from Robeson staff meeting.

The previous week’s meeting about escalation had laid out several scenarios for each. Ellen, Aaron, and myself had starred in a skit titled “When Going Hard Goes Wrong,” which ended in literal laughing out loud and started a conversation about tactics to handle student “misbehavior.” While ostensibly an objective accounting of that meeting, a closer examination of the summary distributed to staff members reveals a bias against escalation. Not only are there simply more entries on the “de-escalation” side, but the entries themselves are not written in the same moral register. “Take a pause” seems to have an edge on “aggressive tone,” and “use humor and prior knowledge of student” could have been lifted directly from Delpit’s

text, while “focus on ‘winning’” somehow insinuates losing. Taking the reins of the meeting, Tina directed us to brainstorm when it was most effective to de-escalate, and when the reverse was true. In true classroom-teacher style, it was a stealth review session

The first hand up belonged to Julia, the director of the Counseling Center and one of two white City natives on the Robeson staff. Her full frame and self-styling—festooned with wooden bangles, a coral beaded choker and perfectly gelled curly hair—set her mode of white womanhood apart from the Gap-meets-Patagonia aesthetic preferred by Kate and Sarah. In her iron-edged West Bay[†] lilt, she argued that escalation is a setup, where students don’t have an honorable way to exit the situation, so they are forced to choose between humiliation and what Eve Tuck (2011) might call “dangerous dignity.”

Josue hopped in with the singsong cadence of a stand-up comic on a roll. “Eight years ago, when I first got here, I was all on this side,” he said, gesturing to the “escalate” portion of the handout. “I would be making this whole speech about The Revolution and how now it isn’t gonna happen cause you didn’t do your homework and shit!” Reflections continued around the circle, most following Josue’s model of veteran wisdom for folks greener in the game.

Arnold, a white special education teacher in his mid-fifties, mused, “The longer I have been doing this, it’s . . . When it’s out of anger, and out of frustration, it just doesn’t work, and it takes so much out of you.”

Elevated arm crooked hesitantly, longtime white Humanities teacher Leonard peered over his glasses intently, carefully choosing his words after the friend of the chair nodded his way.⁶

One question I have is about when our students, or some of our students, get used to being communicated with, or only with anger. Having students listen to directions or concern when it’s not coming from that place becomes challenging. So I wonder how do we use escalation, but also, *how do we build students* so that that is not a place that we or they have to go to for communication?

† “The West Bay” is a tongue-in-cheek phrase used to describe San Francisco. “The East Bay” is the standard name for the collection of towns and cities in and around Alameda county, including Oakland, Berkeley, and Emeryville, and though The City is obviously on the west side of the San Francisco Bay, it is less commonly referred to as the West Bay.

In my notes from the meeting, there is a string of deeply etched exclamation points and question marks next to my jottings for Leonard's remark. I was struck so deeply by his choice of passive grammatical construction—particularly from an English teacher whose department obsessed for years about how to teach active sentence construction. He was leaping over himself to create distance from an identifiable locus of authority. He only used the first person in reference to questioning—*I wonder*—thus highlighting his identity as an intellectual but sidestepping his institutional role both in the school and in the broader racial power structure. Because of these grammatical gymnastics, young people first appear in Leonard's rendering as stranded in a series of circumstances beyond their control. They “get used to being communicated with” anger because “that place” is ostensibly natural for adults in their lives.

Leonard's insinuations echo Daniel Patrick Moynihan's infamous “tangle of pathology” (1965) characterization of Black families, along with a century's worth of policy landscapes and social science research dominated by racialized notions of family structure, sexual propriety, and heteropatriarchal respectability in relation to the civic worth of Black people in the Americas. In the US, this anxiety was at fever pitch during the Reconstruction era, when the Freedman's Bureau enforced marriage upon recently emancipated men as a requirement not only for their pensions, but at times as a requisite for their freedom itself (Ferguson 2004). While pathologizing discourse about Black sexuality and domesticity is largely carried out in the register of the moral, it also had material and civic consequences because “African American poverty was often explained by reverting back to the question of African American intimate relations and denying the irresolvability and historicity of state and capital's own exploitative practices” (Ferguson 2004: 86) that position Black households in perpetual economic precarity. Thus, when Leonard deploys the cultural deficit frame that has become par for the course in state charter applications and KIPP⁷ teacher-training manuals, he joins over a century of postemancipation fretting over the competence of Black families in the Americas.

Leonard was no neoliberal technocrat—he was an avowed antiracist activist and board member of the People's Educators, a leftist organization focused on building the skills and sustainability of equity-minded teachers. His political ethos sets in even starker relief his query “How do we build students,” a single turn of phrase that invokes both a messianic notion of teachers as the Great Architects of humans and a settler-colonial imperative to develop this oh-so-Black *terra nullius*. He reneges on his role as an

authority figure again as he shrouds screaming at children in obligation. It's a place *we have to go* to until we shift not the geographies of power, but, in his framing, *the geography of the students themselves*. Leonard's apparent juxtaposition of white supremacist ideologies and progressive multiracial commitments is an example of how the former is foundational to the latter; the (lack of) mismatch between these two stances sparks the onset of dystopian malaise.

Whether described in Leonard's words as a weighty "*some of our kids*," "just a few kids," or "the same ten kids," as was bandied about in an impromptu upper-class staff ranting session a few months earlier, these seemingly neutral terms for apportioning the student body actually function as racialized signifiers of blackness. When I asked in that rant session who people thought the "ten kids" were, Kate's response was, "Well, you know—the ones who are always in the hall!" Laughter followed, but I pressed further, asking each person to write their own list and see if we were actually on the same page. Of the five other staff present, the students appearing on at least three of the six lists were Nate, Meisha, Tarika, DeAndre, Nashanta, Azizi, Arturo, and Cyarea (only DeAndre and Tarika appeared on all five). After a little NBA draft-style discussion nominating additional students, I mentioned that all the students were Black. "Nah-uh, what about Arturo?" Kate fired back. Apparently, the presence of one Latinx kid, whose adjudicated status and choice of AAVE⁸ arguably blackened him, evacuated the blackness of the Usual Suspects. Further, the collective list was mostly girls, reflecting a pervasively gendered framing of propriety in the Robeson space, one that I take up as a central concern in the next chapter, along with Kate's predilection to selective colorblindness.

Settling Justice: Coloniality and the Robeson Racioscape

In the meeting at hand, Aaron deployed the Usual Suspect rhetoric when he asked us to keep in mind how great Robeson students are, reminding us that "the problems are a distinct minority, so don't let them set the tone." Ironically, *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903) sat prominently on Aaron's office bookshelf, as he echoed W. E. B. Du Bois's century-old ruminations on how it feels to be a problem. Shifting gears from reflection to action steps, Aaron asked what support teachers felt they needed from administration and from each other to effectively de-escalate encounters with students. Curiously,

this was the point in the meeting when the Escalaters stepped forward, citing one example after another where students with whom they sparred in the hallway were not suspended when the teachers thought they should be, or that students “got off easy” by the time they got to Tina and Aaron.

Aaron pushed back on this assertion, saying bluntly, “It’s okay to escalate with kids, but don’t be surprised if you get disrespected. It’s happened to me, but if *I* started it, *I’m* not gonna be pissed.” He thumped his hand below where his button-up shirt parted, to emphasize the “I”s, his caved chest inverting Mr. Agusalim’s braggadocio. His physical performance of humility could have been a tactic to compel the Escalaters to depersonalize student conflict or an impromptu impassioned reflection; this ambiguity between strategy and spontaneity was a hallmark of Aaron’s leadership style.

“Well, maybe we should be pissed!” Kate retorted, amid a gurgle of side chatter and fidgeting that had erupted. She insisted that achieving a social justice mission meant holding kids to higher behavioral standards through increased disciplinary penalties. In the familiar strident voice that I could hear barking out equations through the wall that separated our classrooms, she argued that it was important for teachers to stand their ground with students.

As a school, we need it to be the Apocalypse to be in the hallway when you are not supposed to. The only ones who pop off on me are the ones I don’t know, and honestly at that moment I don’t care. This is not your school, right? This is our school. That’s it. You can disrespect me, and you can get a referral—that’s it. I am not going to provide therapy in the hallway, I am not going to think about your trauma. Get in your classroom—that is your only choice. We *all* need to flex on this a little bit. Often, when kids are being out of pocket in my class, I have them go outside and read the name on the door—I’m like, “That’s not your name, that’s my name. So what I said goes,” and that’s all it needs to be.

Woven into the ire of this soliloquy are three key markers of Robeson’s racial terrain. First, in the deluge of Black women’s voices from her colleagues Nyla and Zahra to Lisa Delpit’s studied prose speaking to the importance of building relationships with students, Kate still insists that she “doesn’t care” when that gulf of knowing results in confrontation. In that moment, her feelings trump the information that she been known about pedagogical best practices, ignoring the gentle moral directives Tina and Aaron offered in the “Escalate vs. De-escalate” handout from just fifteen minutes earlier. Even in Robeson’s color-conscious progressive space where institutional

narratives of racism are locally hegemonic, the enactment of policy is still overdetermined by the affective experiences of individual nonblack people, resulting in a pattern of *emotionally contingent politics* whereby cerebral commitments to racial justice are undermined by nonblack people's visceral commitment to order.

Second, there is an active *denial of Black suffering* indexed by her opposition to “providing therapy in the hallway.” From a rudimentary labor perspective, a teacher's contract involves only so many hours for so many tasks, and the chronic underfunding of California's schools ensures that far too many tasks are packed into far too few hours. However, Kate was not arguing that she didn't have the skills or time to effectively counsel students. Instead, her remarks and her pedagogy more broadly position DeAndre and them in what Saidiya Hartman and Frank Wilderson call the “position of the unthought” (2003). Her declaration that “I will not think about your trauma” in the context of a racial slave-estate built and maintained through violence effectively means “I will not think about *you*,” thus evacuating the possibility of a Black subject in the sociopolitical field of the school. Kate then reminds us of the ruse of agency in the afterlife of slavery: “Get into the classroom, that is your only choice.”

Finally, to rationalize her #WhiteFeels[‡] and the denial of Black subjectivity, Kate positions Robeson as a colonial settlement in which she has rightful dominion. Rather than a benevolent vision resonant with the “Community, Social Justice, Independent Thinkers” mission of Robeson, Kate here advances a plainly imperial view of the school space: “This is not your school—it is our school.” Employing the spatial settler strategy of possessive nomenclature (“read the name on the door”) and then using that name to justify ownership of the land, Kate then drafts the rest of the staff to join forces with her—“We *all* need to flex on this.” Her inclusion of all staff members in her colonial imperative follows the logic of the settler-slave estate in which all white folks are settlers, regardless of their current class position (Smith 2016). In the afterlife of slavery, this ubiquity of enforcement has transmogrified into the figure of the white police officer, whose

‡ #WhiteFeels, closely related to #WhiteTears, is a hashtag used by race-conscious social media users to highlight the fragility of white liberal allyship, and to more broadly critique the centering of white people's emotional experiences at the expense of material costs to Black lives and lives of color. For more on #WhiteFeels, see Damon Young, “White Tears, Explained for White People Who Don't Get It” (2015).

authority is embodied in every white person (Martinot and Sexton 2003). Slippage, though, is primary in this kind of assertion of authority, which perhaps amplifies its expression.

Kate seems oblivious to her relative privilege during her diatribe, not only in the obvious racial and geographic sense, but also of her classed position in the uneasy hierarchy of the staff. Not every adult could tell kids to “read the name on the door” because lower-paid staffers like paraprofessionals and AmeriCorps interns who did not have a teaching credential or a master’s degree largely had to share classrooms or migrate from one room to another in order to work with students. Further, when compared to certified teachers, the folks in these contingent roles were more likely to be Black or to have grown up in The City, if not both. What, then, does it mean for Kate to recruit this multiracial room of adults—some Frisco natives, some transplants, some Black, and some wishing they were—to the project of “flexing” in the hallways? As I discuss in the next section, while a broad swath of members of the school community engage in racial mapping, they do so from different vantage points in the social topography, resulting in vastly different renderings of the grounds.

Kate’s colonial stance also extends into the space of The City. During our one-to-one interview, I asked Kate about her experience living in the traditionally Black Western Addition neighborhood. She abdicated any role in gentrification, reasoning that only one new bar had opened in the Moe during her tenure and that the Divisadero Business District was still “pretty sparse.” The fact that her residence, along with hundreds of other out-of-town renters *preceded* and indeed facilitated the slew of new restaurants on Divisadero Street (including one that specializes in [delicious] five-dollar toast) eludes her. At the moment of her “Apocalypse” outburst, Kate lived in the Mission District, where private Google buses have helped to transform the historic Latinx neighborhood into a bedroom community for Silicon Valley. Kate’s racial map of Frisco omits her agency as an actor, and pulls the city out of its historical context. Her presence is analogous to anyone else’s, and her “cheap” \$1,700 rent is happenstance, rather than design. “Yeah, so far it’s been, like, ‘Oh, my neighbors are Latin.’ It hasn’t been like I’m displacing somebody because I’m white. It’s just that I’m renting this place, but you could have rented this place because it’s cheap and it’s not really very nice.” In order to accomplish her feat, Kate invokes her rights as an autological subject (Povinelli 2006), an actor unencumbered by history or relationality who functions as the basic building block of liberal civil society. The “you” she calls on as alibi doubly invokes both me, as

a Black woman colleague, and her “Latin” neighbors as those in search of something “cheap” and “not really nice.” As an aside, a year later Kate was no longer living in the Mission or teaching at Robeson, not because she had been pushed out for her approach, but because she had left the K–12 classroom to embark on a career in educational policy.

While the comparison between hallways and plantations may seem grandiose, reading across space-time is a crucial tactic for writing Black futures. When we think of the contemporary public school as a plantation site, the easy move is to create an analogy between cruel masters/racist school staff on the one hand, and trapped slaves/impoverished students on the other. McKittrick pushes us to think past diametric frames to imagine a contested, collaborative flow of meaning rooted in historical experience: “As the plantation provides the future through which contemporary racial geographies and violences make themselves known, it is precisely within our collective plantation futures that fractured and multiple (Black and nonblack) perspectives on place and belonging are fostered and debated” (2011: 950). By lifting up the role of cross-racial negotiations over the meaning of place, McKittrick offers us an open set of plantation futures for the ‘hoods of San Francisco. Her work also allows us to engage with slavery not as an analogy for the present, but as an ongoing structural relation from which we are still seeking relief—it is the territory, not the map (Wynter 2006). To the contrary, any rhetorical moves that position present carcerality and dispossession as “like slavery” or even as *The New Jim Crow* (Alexander 2010) inadvertently assert the *plantation* (as) *past*, and reinforce the hegemonic narrative of emancipation as a truth rather than a promise. In the Robeson context, the founders and school leaders nurture the “fractured and multiple” nature of plantation futures by acknowledging structural racism, and attempt to deploy Robeson’s curriculum, disciplinary practices, and governance structure as tools for winning the struggle for racial justice.

In Robeson’s own promotional materials, the institution draws on the fantasy of prospective teachers who want to be “part of the solution”:

One thing that is unique is that we are a school for social justice. Words like justice and equity get thrown around a lot here in the Bay Area, and sometimes it’s hard to know exactly what people mean by them . . . Many working class families, especially African-Americans, are being driven out of the city by gentrification, and only 13 percent of San Franciscans are children, the lowest percentage of any major city in the country.

One in 100 American adults is incarcerated (2.3 million people)—the highest rate and number in the world. And public policy supports these trends: In California, spending on prisons has skyrocketed for decades while public school spending languishes at 49th in the nation. Here at Robeson, we think social justice means acknowledging the oppression inherent in this context, and making the deliberate choice to be part of the solution.

Because of its spatial location, Robeson discursively functions as an exception nested within another—a progressive sanctuary of liberation pedagogy in the nation’s symbol of liberalism—San Francisco, whose literal “Sanctuary City” status seems to set it apart from the imperatives of nationalism and empire. Frisco, of course, is itself nested in California, the drought-stricken paradise where the globe’s dreams come true. But there is no sanctuary from a world held together by the gravity of the violable Black body. Rather than render Robeson as a bounded antiblack space, I want to remap Robeson and other progressive dystopian spaces like it as coordinates in a global antiblack space. Its terrain is contiguous with Ferguson and New York, with Charleston and Seine-Saint-Denis, with Santo Domingo and Capetown.

At the same time, we need to remap multiracial modes of contemporary progressivism into the continental reach of white supremacy and antiblack racism. Each of the Robeson staff and school leaders that I have worked with over the past decade is genuinely and unequivocally committed to a vision of racial equity. However, that commitment fails to the extent that they continue to see themselves and their school as working *outside* the bounds of systemic racism, rather than always already ensconced within them. How, though, is this nested exception experienced by those of us who wear the guise of authority while manifesting the afterlife of the slave?

Not All Settlers Are Masters: Uneven Geographies of Power

Each person who pushes through Robeson’s heavy steel door must navigate its racial landscape, resulting in a conflicting set of user-generated maps of the social topography. These power-laden cartographies are reinforced by everyday grammars of belonging: “*their* neighborhoods,” “*our* school,” “*my* classroom,” and the like. Possessive discourses are a tool for staff members

to make positive claims and exhibit pride about student achievement, as well as a method of creating meaning through discourses of distance and proximity. Wrought with tension, these kind of claims on spaces and bodies seek to establish narratives of duty and filiality, but can be met with wariness, particularly across social locations of race.

Such ambivalence was on display at the first Black staff caucus–cum-interview I convened in my classroom, complete with vegan black-eyed peas, mustard greens, and cornbread warmed on hot plates I borrowed from Evelyn, the freshman science teacher. Simone, a middle-class Black math teacher raised in The City, maintained a diplomatic tone, in keeping with her role as a bridge between staff factions, couching her critique in “not all” rhetoric and using the “I statement” format hegemonic in liberal-progressive professional dialogue.

SIMONE: It’s not every teacher, but I feel like sometimes people assume negative intent when they see a Black kid. We have a lotta Black students who are very hungry for Black community. They not only kick it with each other, but try to have solidarity with each other. How they frame that in their little fifteen- and fourteen-year-old minds is a whole different thing! But when they see a teacher coming down the hallway, even if it’s me, or if it’s a white teacher, you can feel that tension with Black students, like “What is he or she gonna say to me?” It’s like this constant bucking against—it’s something that’s been institutionalized throughout their whole education. I think teachers do it subconsciously, thinking “What are they up to? Are they up to no good? Why are they being loud?”

ZAHRA: Loud voices! That’s another thing that’s getting on my nerves—that people assume that just cause a kid is being loud that they are doing something wrong!

Simone highlights how “bucking against” can manifest in reaction to the teacher role, whether it is played by herself or by white staff members. Rather than attributing this tension simply to student resistance or race-neutral “boundary testing,” by linking it in her narrative to a nascent Black solidarity among young people, Simone helps distinguish between the practice of Black solidarity and the simple fact of blackness. The fact that students buck against her as a Black teacher does not mean their actions aren’t racially motivated, a fallacy hawked by the same multiculturalist logic that argues Black cops can’t be racist. Instead, it is an example of how Black teachers navigate the racial terrain of schools in ways that can contradict institutional man-

dates. For instance, duty-driven directives like Kate’s “we need to flex on this” can have a counterintuitive impact on Black teachers; Linwood H. Cousins (1999: 306) noted that when increased policing was desired, “such coercion of teachers, especially those who had tenure, generated increased empathy and acquiescence toward students and their behavior.” At Robeson, this increased empathy was not only manifest by Black teachers, but also by some Frisco native NBPOC⁹ and white staff members who had variously been “blackened” by dint of their use of Black English, familiarity with City geographies, and predilection to call a spade its true name, even when it was “cracker” (or, more common at Robeson, *güero*). Josue was chief among them—notorious for refusing to count down outside his classroom and harboring hallway wanderers in his class during preps, he used his social location as a City-born Pinoy to build connections with Black students and families. Zahra and Simone’s comments come in a broader national context of increased militarization and police presence in schools, particularly those serving Black and Latinx youth (Meiners 2007; Tuzzolo and Hewitt 2006).

The past two decades have seen the emergence of the school-to-prison pipeline as the dominant critical framework for problematizing harsh disciplinary measures in urban schools, with California as a common case study given its infamy as the carceral capital of the US (Gilmore 2007). These critiques infuse Robeson’s institutional common sense, with Simone’s stats class even using racially disproportionate incarceration rates as a topic for learning how to apply the mathematical skill of probability. Like the promotional materials declare, Robeson wants to be “part of the solution” to oppression—recall how Aaron made a deal with the cops to not park in front of the school? However, all this *signaling* of Robeson’s exceptional status have failed to actually *make* Robeson an exception to the rule of Black punishment. Instead, it persists as a manifestation of the school-prison nexus (Meiners 2007).

When put in the context of the other high schools in the district, Robeson’s overall 6 percent suspension rate for students across race puts it in the middle of the pack. The suspension rate spikes to 20 percent for Black students, signaling a major discrepancy in practice, but one that is still normative in San Francisco—five schools had higher suspension rates for Black students, the two highest at 50 percent and 49 percent respectively. However, Robeson actually *is* exceptional in one arena: with a population of 24 percent Black students and 80 percent of student suspensions being for Black students, *Robeson had the most disproportionate suspensions of Black*

students in the city out of all nineteen public high schools serving students in the 2012–13 school year. As could be surmised, this disproportionality in punishment is not equitably distributed. Even though Robeson’s Latinx student population was 54 percent, only 13 percent of suspensions went to Latinx students that year at Robeson. How, then, do we reconcile Robeson’s exceptionally punitive disciplinary practices with its institutional narratives of exception? What are the mechanisms that allow Robeson schoolpeople to continue to celebrate the institution as a “win” for social justice? Further, how do Black folks navigate the contradiction inherent to Robeson’s progressive carcerality?

When I asked Tina, the Asian American coprincipal, to account for the disproportionate number of behavioral referrals and suspensions meted out to Black students at Robeson, she responded at first with a hesitation out of keeping with her self-described “alpha Scorpio” demeanor. Tick-ticking her rhinestone-speckled acrylic nails on the side of her walkie-talkie, she equivocated, “Um, I think it’s . . . I think it’s culturally . . . respo- . . . I think it’s the fact that . . .” Dropping her hands onto the table, she leveled with me.

I think it’s racism. I was trying to think of a different [*pause*] but I think it’s racism. I don’t mean it as a negative way. I think folks who didn’t grow up predominantly in African American culture find high volume extremely disrespectful, whereas my family is very loud. And so, I, although I find it annoying, don’t find it necessarily, like, disrespectful. I think that folks do have an emotional reaction to volume, and our Black students are loud. It’s interesting. When folks write a referral, I see why they’re writing it. A lot of times, the word “volume” comes up, like inappropriate volume. For *you*. That *you* find inappropriate.

For Tina to say that she didn’t mean racism in a “negative way” means she is using a notion of racism that is not synonymous with intentional bigotry and hatred. Her racially coded, indirect language choices allow her to name systemic racism without naming racists. The phrase “folks who didn’t grow up in African American culture” stands in for whiteness, or perhaps for those allied with it—she herself, as a Chinese American woman raised in alabaster Colorado, wasn’t raised around any Black people at all, and yet she doesn’t feel assaulted by raised voices. Further, by saying “My family is very loud,” Tina reaches back to racist caricatures of Chinese people as noisy and uncouth (Shah 2001) as a source of kinship with Black people. That these “folks” have an “emotional reaction” that leads to disproportionate policing and punishment of Black children points again to the outsize role nonblack

affective experiences of blackness play in shaping the practices of progressive political projects.

By leaning on “you” several times, she enacts a supervision style that asks white (and whitened) teachers to take personal responsibility for their disciplinary impulses, rather than lodge the weight of their complaint onto the bodies of Black students. Tina rehearsed this move of turning the lens back onto teachers over and over during her first year as an administrator, and it proved to be an effective implementation of antiracist (if not abolitionist) practice. Tina continued with her analysis, shifting toward the pedagogical responsibilities entailed in assuming white middle-class norms as disciplinary limits. “If we’re gonna define what appropriate volume is, then we have to be explicit about it. What is the appropriate volume, and how are we going to teach that to students, because they’re using this ‘inappropriate volume’ when they’re outside of school, and it would be actually completely appropriate and acceptable.” While the “we” and “they” Tina uses account for how the boundaries of appropriateness are racialized, they also homogenize the Robeson staff into a “we” that subscribes to bourgeois white notions of propriety. Christina Sharpe reminds us that “the weather is the totality of our environments; the weather is the total climate; and that climate is antiblack” (2016: 104). In this “weather,” Black Robeson staff can be pushed from the safety of “we” to the target of “they” at any point during their workday, reflecting the tenuousness of multiracial alliance under the heading of “teacher.”

Speaking from their tenuous position straddling boundaries in the racial landscape, Black staff members shared about a sense of hypervigilance that they brought to work with them. Zahra, a mid-twenties Black woman who grew up moving from one small Bay Area city to another, connected her intimacy with Robeson youth to a sense of structural vulnerability. It was her first year working full-time at Robeson, and her relative youth and supplementary position as a guidance counselor made her a target for teaching staff to pull rank.

Like in my classroom, if I have my door open and like we are laughing and joking and singing something and it’s after the bell, I’m thinking, “Is that going to be a problem?” And it has been a problem. Last week there was an interaction in my classroom with Mr. Agusalim and one of the students: he busted in after the student and was like, “Where’s your pass?” And he was asking me if he had showed me his pass. And I was like, “No, I knew he was in my room, but I’m helping another student and

I'll get to him in a second." But he ignored me and said to the student in a clearly angry way, like, "Well, where's your pass? I just talked to you." And the student escalated then too. So there is a certain level of policing that I feel on a day-to-day basis.

Mr. Agusalim projected a sense of self-importance so great that most of the staff referred to him as "Mr. Agusalim" even in the casual environment of Robeson, where the principals went by first names to fellow staff members. A child of middle-class Indonesian immigrants, Mr. Agusalim had moved to San Francisco from the Midwest and often functioned as the political and pedagogical advocate of "law and order" solutions to Robeson's ills. Here, his drive to monitor Black children's movement was so powerful that it dissolved the boundaries around Zahra's classroom, neutralizing her authority in her own space and literally embodying police presence in the ostensibly safe space of the classroom. The Black teacher's classroom, invaded in this way by a colored carceral presence, becomes indistinguishable from the MUNI trolley car boarded by transit cops looking to ticket those without passes, or from the New England boardinghouse full of fugitive slaves, or from public housing apartments in the Sunnydale projects down the hill that are subject to arbitrary inspection by a social worker.

The connection to bondage is one made over and over by Black Robeson folks across boundaries of staff/student, professional class/working class, and native/transplant. Maurice, a student wellness advocate in his early twenties who was raised in The 'Sco,¹⁰ talked about his desire to be "free."

Sometimes I have to catch myself, 'cause I wanna be free too. Sometimes the kids are singin' in the hallway, and I'll start singin' with 'em—they need to be conscious of their volume, sure, but shut 'em down? No! But I have to be careful because I don't want other staff to be questioning me like, "How is he setting an example if he is just like the kids?" If I see a teacher that's not of my race, I will be different, because that's the way I grew up. If I see someone of another race, I feel like I have to hold more of a standard.

Rather than name whiteness, Maurice used "not of my race" to index a Black/nonblack framework for how he operationalizes his code switching, or the imperative to "be different" as soon as a nonblack colleague spies him singing along with the Jacka, Erk tha Jerk, or whichever other Bay Area rapper had dropped a hot single that month. Further, by saying he "wanna be free too," Maurice positioned Black Robeson youth as his role models for

the embodiment of freedom, articulating a collective desire for the liberation soon to come.

Simone built on Maurice's contribution, forging a more academic notion of freedom in relation to the demands of the racial landscape. Like him, she was also born and raised in The City, and attended elite magnet schools as a kid.

But it's hard because it's still important for us to be free and manifest who we truly are with our students *and* at the same time manifest great thinking. Sometimes those misunderstandings between Black and non-Black staff suppress that energy that we need. I was an undergrad math major, and there was no one in my department who was Black. My idea of being professional, of being mathematical, was completely shaped by that environment.

Expressing an ethos that emphasizes the “warm” in the “warm demander” pedagogy celebrated by Delpit, Simone refused to separate Black excellence and Black ratchetry. Her classroom was one where she combined languages and habitus across class and race, mixing in bits of Tagalog and AAVE into her instruction around mathematical concepts, striking bus-stop poses and Instagram duck faces during a lesson. She located the Black/nonblack divide as a site for “misunderstanding” DeAndre as a scholar instead of a troublemaker. Simone's narrative of Black isolation in intellectual spaces recalls the impulse to solidarity that she discussed among loud students in the hallway, as well as Robeson's contiguity with other academic spaces governed by white norms, even in the absence of white students. Her story resonates with Maurice's and Zahra's to reveal a tension between hypervigilance around behavioral norms and a longing for embodied Black liberty. Robeson's racialized carceral logics land hard on the bodies of Black adults as they, too, traverse plantation futures of the school's hallways.

Frisco Fugitivity: *La Perruque* and the Apocalypse

Twelve feet wide, fifty yards long—Robeson's corridors are spatial containers for the encounter between the state and the body, and yet we must pay as much attention to the *when* as to the *where* of Frisco's racial map. Temporality is what transforms space into distance, line into boundary, stasis into movement. Only by holding both space (geography, body) and time (history, memory) in the same frame can we begin to trace the travel of

Black and nonblack subjects across Robeson’s racial terrain. The temporal is a zone of opportunity for subaltern subversion. In lieu of the spatial strategies of the “proper”—owning a condo instead of living at in the precarity of a Section 8 subsidy, having one’s name printed on a classroom door—the ever-improper Other must engage temporal tactics: “Because it does not have a place, a tactic depends on time—it is always on the watch for opportunities that must be seized ‘on the wing.’ Whatever it wins, it does not keep” (de Certeau 1984: xix). In this light, we need to think more about the bodies who escape into the hall, through ever-craftier methods of leaving class—and even those grown-up bodies who seek their own freedom in the hall space under the cover of teacher authority.

For those who “do not have a place” to seize time, they have to reshape the content of both time and space in their own interests. Writing about the practices of popular culture in the twilight of Fordist-Keynesianism, Michel de Certeau uses a factory metaphor to flesh out the idea of *la perruque*, in which “the worker who indulges in *la perruque* actually diverts time (not goods, since he uses only scraps) from the factory for work that is free, creative, and precisely not directed toward profit” and is able “to confirm his solidarity with other workers or his family through *spending* his time in this way” (de Certeau 1984: 25–26). While the relation to time seems akin to the whimsy of DeAndre’s wanderings, the disorienting wealth of deindustrialized San Francisco, flush with financial-industry cash but all but unlivable for the few remaining Black families seems irreconcilable with a political economy based on near-full employment in manufacturing. Given that gap, what kinds of work can *la perruque* do to help us understand both the repurposing of *time* in the liminal spaces of Robeson, and the repurposing of *space* in the liminal times of the school day?

As a state site, Robeson is pressed upon to produce goods, not in the sense of the bolts of cloth or cartons of processed foods that are churned out of a factory, but in the form of reams and reams of paper, gigabytes of data that represent student achievement: test scores, attendance rolls, graduation rates and college eligibility and matriculation stats. Giggles, tears, and skirmishes in the hall will never show up in reports for the Department of Education, and vie for each minute that could otherwise be spent analyzing Gloria Anzaldúa quotes, breaking down the asthma rates in Bayview–Hunters Point, or otherwise *on the job* at Robeson, however subversive the content of that job may be. Thus, through *la perruque* Robeson folks in the halls challenge productivity itself as the basis for Black belonging in the school space. Who better than the descendant of a slave to devise

ways to unshackle themselves from the task at hand? Idleness proves to be an effective abolitionist tactic. In an institution geared toward “winning” progressive reforms, idleness delegitimizes the game itself, much like Kaep taking a knee just over a mile from the schoolhouse.¹¹

Following this line of inquiry, are these kids what we might call the “functional surrogates” of fugitive slaves (Wacquant 2002)? If we are seriously engaging the plantation as an analytic, do Robeson students transform the hallway into a maroon space? What then does that say about the value of class time, especially when the classes they are cutting are teaching Fanon, Anzaldúa, and Manning Marable? Is the vision of liberatory public school serving Black kids always already doomed? On the other hand, what can maroonage mean in the contemporary US, where the map of unceded Native territory is coterminous with the borders of the settler state? Does it mean that instead of fleeing into the negotiated safety of land under indigenous control, the flight of settled slaves takes us beyond the state?

Given that maroon spaces were historically autonomous alternate social spaces for Black survival, lasting from months to years, ensconced and heavily guarded in forest thickets and mountain ranges across the Americas, it seems like the moment-to-moment tactics at work in this chapter, are not analogous to maroonage.¹² Instead, like the hallways themselves, the kids in the hall occupy a liminal space between liberation and captivity—the peripatetic space of fugitivity. Tactics, in the Certeauian sense, *take* time and space. They are possessive, durative, and expansive practices that gesture toward, but do not instantiate, freedom. Robeson’s hallways are a snapshot of blackness in motion, in one moment traveling in syncopation with the “ten, nine, eight!” booming down the hall, in another dancing away from the nonevent of 1863 toward the asymptote of abolition.¹³

Movement serves as a mechanism that seeks to fill the gulf between what we might call “freedom,” or liberation on the one hand, and “emancipation,” or formal inclusion in the (late) liberal state on the other. The trajectories of Robeson’s schoolpeople into and through the halls function as a kind of Frisco fugitivity, a flight that in its search for a landing itself manifests the definitional longing of blackness—an embodied declaration that like Maurice, we “wanna be free, too.” In this sense, liberation is a velocity rather than a state of being. Made more poignant as an escape from Robeson’s left-progressive curriculum, this fleshy Black flight is not articulated as a politics qua politics—a “We demand more Black studies” or “Hire more teachers of color at Robeson now!” which requires the (illusion of) access to the proper—but rather as a ratchetry that is its refusal. Not in opposi-

tion to Robeson but not *not* in opposition to Robeson, the corridors are the exception's exception, a space filled with the excess of those without access to place.

Frisco fugitivity is the operationalization of plantation futures. Restlessness here is an embodied abolitionist practice—a loving discontent that is “the general antagonism to politics looming outside every attempt to politicise,” in this case just on the other side of the door (Moten and Harney 2013: 20). Kate might have been right when she said it should be the Apocalypse—the end of the world—for Robeson students to be in the hallway. What she may not have realized is that it was *her world as she knows it* that they are hinting toward ending. By being *out* of pocket, these ratchet young fugitives spatialize the abolitionist imperative to uncivil disobedience and remind us of the painful naïveté of respectability as a strategy for Black citizenship. In the next chapter, I turn to the gendered dimensions of incivility at Robeson, and to the institutional expulsion of those to both the right and the left of its progressive tightrope.